

Voluntary National Standards for Election Audits – A Practical Guide

Executive Summary

Election audits are a vital tool for analyzing and enhancing the quality of election administration throughout the United States. With numerous types of audits targeting different aspects of the election process and a variety of methodologies employed across the country, each state is responsible for establishing its own audit policies and procedures. This guide examines essential elements that contribute to successful election audits, providing examples of application and discussing how various jurisdictions may address specific challenges. By using this guide to assess and inform audit practices, jurisdictions can enhance checks and balances and reinforce the trustworthiness of election administration. This version of the guide was adopted by the U.S. Election Assistance Commission on X date as Version 1.

Table of Contents

Executive Summary	1
Table of Contents	1
Introduction	2
Using the Standards	4
Standards Framework	4
Discussion of Standards	8
Objective	
Authorization	8
Ethics	9
Funding	11
Impartiality	12
Independence	14
Professional	
Competence	18
Standardization	20

Effective	
Appropriateness	22
Efficacy.....	23
Flexibility	25
Secure	
Privacy/Confidentiality	27
Security	28
Accountable	
Public Communication	31
Transparency	32

Introduction

Elections are complex undertakings that require careful planning, precise execution, and public confidence in the results. Audits play a critical role in verifying that elections comply with laws and procedures, reinforcing trust in the process. However, as laws, technology, and public expectations evolve, audit practices must adapt to remain effective and credible. Currently, there are no national standards for election audits, and the differences in election audits across jurisdictions can lead to unclear expectations. Establishing voluntary national professional standards addresses this gap by providing a clear framework for consistency and supporting election officials in implementing best practices.

This guide delivers a universal set of voluntary professional standards for election audits in the United States. Created in collaboration by the U.S. Election Assistance Commission and members of its advisory boards, these standards are intended to assist election officials, policymakers, and stakeholders in planning, executing, and evaluating audits across diverse jurisdictions.

Although jurisdictions' needs are unique, the standards are designed to be applicable across all 50 states, five U.S. territories, and the District of Columbia, and adaptable to a wide variety of election audits.

Election audits can take place before, during, or after an election. The chart below provides examples of some common election audit types, though jurisdictions may conduct other audits tailored to their unique needs and requirements.

Example: Auditing Activities Before, During, and After an Election

Audit	Description
Access audit	An assessment of whether legal procedures were followed to ensure the election's accessibility to voters with disabilities.
Automated independent ballot audit	An audit that recounts all paper ballots through a different tabulation system to confirm the accuracy of the election results. This audit method provides a visualization of each ballot.
Ballot design audit	An assessment of the usability of the ballot(s) in an election, often focusing on voters with disabilities or voters who use ballots in languages other than English.
Ballot reconciliation audit	A comparison of the published election results with the number of voters who signed poll books during in-person voting or whose mail ballot envelopes were checked in.
Compliance or procedural audit	An audit that examines whether the established processes and procedures were followed throughout the election.
Eligibility audit	A process to verify that the ballots that were counted were legally cast.
Hash Verification	A process that compares cryptographic hash values of the voting system software to the certified baseline values to ensure that no unauthorized software changes occurred.
Legal audit	An assessment of whether election practices comply with all applicable local, state, and federal laws.
Logic and accuracy testing	A test to examine whether voting systems are counting votes correctly before vote tabulation begins, usually by creating a test deck of ballots and running them through the systems.
Post-election tabulation audit	An audit in which a sample of ballots are selected and retabulated, and the results are compared to the originally reported vote totals.
Risk-limiting tabulation audit	A procedure for checking a sample of ballots (or voter-verifiable records) that provides a prespecified statistical chance of correcting the reported outcome of an election if the reported outcome is wrong (that is, if a full hand count would reveal an outcome different from the reported outcome).
Voting system postelection audit	An examination of voting system components after the election to verify that the system operated in its certified, authorized configuration throughout the election period.

Although the guide provides examples and scenarios, election procedures vary significantly depending on the type of audit, office size, available resources, and local laws. Therefore, officials should exercise their professional judgment and adapt these standards to suit their specific situations.

Using the Standards

These standards provide a voluntary framework for officials involved in planning and conducting new or existing election audits. Rather than focusing on a particular audit type or segment of the election process, the standards are designed to be broadly applicable to any election audit. They are intended not as a checklist, but as guideposts for policymakers and election officials to design, refine, and implement audits within their jurisdictions.

Flexibility is a foundational principle of these standards, acknowledging the variety of election administration practices and the unique constraints posed by resources, geography, statutory frameworks, and other factors. There is no single "correct" method for implementing the standards, and the discussion sections explore different approaches for meeting the standards under various circumstances.

When discussing a standard publicly, officials are encouraged to cite the standard and then explain how they are currently implementing that principle. Where constraints are present, they should be explained, citing the relevant statute or regulation where possible. For example, for the standard of "Transparency," a theoretical jurisdiction might say:

*"We adhere to the U.S. Election Assistance Commission's Standards for Election Audits. For the standard of **transparency**, we provide ... (for example) two weeks of public notice before each audit and opportunities for public observation. Because the space in our courthouse is limited, we can only accommodate 35 public observers at any given time and will rotate observers through once we reach capacity."*

Standards Framework

The standards contained here are organized alphabetically within topic, enabling officials to identify applicable standards quickly. Each topic is labeled, followed by the standard itself, and a discussion section that contains examples of how the standard might be applied follows.

Topic	Standards
Objective	Authorization, Ethics, Funding, Impartiality, & Independence
Professional	Competence & Standardization
Effective	Appropriateness, Efficacy, & Flexibility
Secure	Privacy/Confidentiality, & Security
Accountable	Public Communication & Transparency

Topic: Objective

Objectivity in election audits means that they are conducted under proper legal authority, with transparent funding and unbiased oversight. This foundation is essential for public trust, as it demonstrates that audits are not only authorized but are conducted without undue influence or conflicts of interest. When audits are objective, stakeholders can be confident that the process is fair and lawful.

Standards

- **Authorization:** Audits should be designed and conducted at the direction of an Independent Audit Committee to be determined by each individual state. The Audit Committee could be an independent body from the state government, or at the very least, report to a committee of the legislature that is mandated by statute to be bipartisan. The Audit Committee should not be controlled by the chief election official at the state or local level. However, the Audit Committee should provide a form of membership and accept input from election officials, political parties, statisticians, election consultants, CPAs, lawyers, and members of the public. This process should be authorized in law or regulation where possible.
- **Ethics:** Auditors should follow documented ethical principles throughout their work.
- **Funding:** Audits should be adequately funded by applicable public resources.
- **Impartiality:** Audits must be conducted without bias, prejudice, or undue influence and instead focus solely on factual evidence to reach fair and objective conclusions.
- **Independence:** Auditors, and those who design and control the audits should maintain a degree of independence from the work being audited, and neither the audit process nor results should depend solely on the chief election official.

Topic: Professional

Professionalism in election audits means that those conducting and overseeing audits possess the necessary expertise and adhere to consistent, well-defined procedures. This ensures that audits are performed competently and reliably, reducing the risk of errors and increasing the credibility of the results.

Standards

- **Competence:** The audit team should collectively possess the necessary knowledge, skills, and experience to conduct an audit effectively and in compliance with professional standards, legal requirements, and the specific context of the election.

- **Standardization:** Audits should be a standardized part of the election process that can be planned for in the regular course of election preparation.

Topic: Effective

Effectiveness ensures that audits achieve their intended goal of providing meaningful and actionable insights that can improve election processes. By focusing on efficacy, appropriateness, and flexibility, effective audits are timely, relevant, and adaptable to changing circumstances. This ensures that audits provide the greatest benefit to both election officials and the public.

Standards

- **Appropriateness:** The scope, methods, and evidence examined by the audit should be clearly defined and correspond to the goals of the audit.
- **Efficacy:** Audits should be conducted with a clear purpose in mind, be completed in time for the results to be useful, and include a plan for analyzing and utilizing the results and/or data gathered during the audit.
- **Flexibility:** Audit processes must include ways to identify and respond to unexpected challenges or constraints.

Topic: Secure

Security and confidentiality are critical to protecting sensitive election and voter information throughout the audit process. Robust safeguards prevent unauthorized access, tampering, or disclosure, preserving the integrity of both the audit and the election itself. Secure audits help maintain public confidence and ensure compliance with legal requirements.

Standards

- **Privacy/Confidentiality:** Confidential data and voter privacy should be protected in accordance with applicable laws and regulations. Where these constraints limit public disclosure, they should be explained.
- **Security:** Audits should follow established security best practices and be conducted with trusted technology and personnel. Nothing done in the course of the audit should prevent election officials from using audited equipment, ballots, or other records for their intended election purpose.

Topic: Accountable

Accountability ensures that audit processes and outcomes are transparent and open to public inspection. Clear communication and accessible reporting allow stakeholders to understand, evaluate, and trust the audit process. Accountability enhances public trust

and fosters ongoing improvement by enabling organizations to learn from each audit and effectively address identified concerns.

Standards

- **Public Communication:** Election officials should communicate with the public about the goal(s), process, and outcome of the audit to promote public confidence.
- **Transparency:** The goals, methods/procedures, and results of the audit should be clearly documented and publicly accessible, consistent with applicable law and regulation. Public observation of the audit process is desirable but must not interfere. Where constraints are present, they should be explained.

Disclaimer

Election audit laws and practices differ significantly across states. The discussion of standards that follows highlights potential approaches for meeting standards; however, these examples are illustrative rather than exhaustive, comprehensive, or universally applicable. Ultimately, election auditing officials are responsible for interpreting and applying these standards within their respective jurisdictions.

Discussion of Standards

Authorization

Audits should be conducted at the direction of the chief election official at the state or local level, and authorized in law or regulation where possible.

Discussion

State and local government officials hold primary responsibility for administering elections within their jurisdictions. This includes ensuring that the election audit processes are conducted safely, securely, accurately, and remain accessible. These officials operate under federal and state laws and regulations and are accountable to various oversight bodies for the conduct of elections.

Audits often rely on access to evidence or artifacts that election officials are tasked with securing and maintaining. When these records or systems are used in an audit, their use needs to be managed in a manner that preserves their integrity and safeguards against tampering. Although maintaining the statutory chain of custody and ensuring election security are primary considerations, oversight procedures differ based on local statutes, resources, and administrative methods. Typically, audits require approval from election officials, but the extent of election officials' participation in the audit process varies depending on the specific requirements of each jurisdiction.

Most states explicitly authorize audits in statute, which clarifies the authority under which audits are conducted and maintains a baseline of uniformity within a state. The level of detail in these laws varies significantly from state to state, however. Some states specify a particular audit method, while others offer several options that local jurisdictions can choose between. In some cases, when new audit types are being considered, audit pilots are specifically authorized by statute. In other cases, pilots may be conducted under existing laws and regulations.

Considerations

When overseeing election audits, officials must navigate a range of legal, operational, and practical factors to ensure the process is compliant. A few key factors to keep in mind are:

- The rules for audits vary depending on state or local laws.
- Officials must make sure audits follow the law and are done in a way that keeps the election process secure.

- Flexibility may be needed to try new audit methods, but any adjustments should still follow legal requirements.

Sample Language

*“For the standard of **authorization**, we conduct audits that are... (for example)*

- ...in accordance with state election laws and regulations.”*
- ...under the oversight of the chief election official.”*
- ...authorized by a pilot program under state law.”*

Ethics

Auditors should follow documented ethical principles throughout their work.

Discussion

Election officials are bound by ethical principles designed to safeguard the election process and produce trustworthy results. Not only do ethical principles set expectations for how election administrators conduct themselves, but they can also be helpful tools for explaining why things are done in specific ways. Even offices that do not have a unique code of ethics can point to ethical principles found in oaths of office, workplace codes of conduct, and various statutes and regulations.

Ethical Standards for Election Administration

For offices that do not maintain a formal code of conduct, the following [ethical standards for election administration](#), developed by a bipartisan working group convened by The American Law Institute, can serve as a practical reference point for guiding ethical behavior and professional expectations.

1. Adhere to the law. Election officials have a duty to administer the law as written and interpreted by the relevant authorities.
2. Protect and defend the integrity of the election process. Election officials have a duty to ensure the integrity of elections and to safeguard against unfounded attacks on the integrity of the election process.
3. Promote transparency in the conduct of elections. Election officials have a duty to make election administration transparent to the public.
4. Treat all participants in the election process impartially. Election officials have an obligation to treat all participants in the electoral process impartially, including voters, candidates, citizens, and political committees.
5. Demonstrate personal integrity. Election officials have a duty to conduct themselves honestly and forthrightly in all interactions with superiors, peers, candidates, campaign officials, and the general public.
6. Practice the highest level of ethics and stewardship. Election officials have a duty to expend public funds carefully and foster respect among employees and volunteers.
7. Advance professional excellence. Election officials have a duty to stay informed about election laws and new developments in election management.

An example of how ethics can be applied in practice is by requiring auditors to disclose any personal or financial ties to candidates, campaigns, or vendors involved in the election, thereby helping to ensure that audits are conducted impartially and ethically.

Considerations

Failure to uphold ethical principles during election audits can have profound and far-reaching implications, including:

- Erosion of public trust
- Damage to professional credibility

- Legal and regulatory consequences

Sample Language

*“For the standard of **ethics**, we conduct audits... (for example)*

- *...where all participants take an official oath of office to uphold all laws.”*
- *...that adhere to a published code of conduct, ensuring professional behavior and accountability throughout the process.”*
- *...in compliance with established ethical standards.”*

Funding

Audits should be adequately funded by applicable public resources.

Discussion

Adequate resources are essential for election audits. Funding varies by state, with some elections funded locally and others receiving state support. The certifying jurisdiction typically covers the costs of audits and includes these expenses in the election budget. Key expenses may include staff, facility rentals, and supplies. Technology adds another layer of expense, as many types of audits require specialized software or equipment, such as for statistical calculations, automated analyses of files or databases, or coordination across jurisdictions. Audit costs can fluctuate each election.

To ensure impartiality, it is recommended that funding for election audits be sourced from state and local budgets rather than external entities. Public financing of election audits helps preserve the independence and accountability of election processes. Furthermore, several states have enacted legislation restricting or prohibiting private funding for election administration, including audits.

For transparency, audit documentation should specify both the cost and the sources of funding for audits.

Considerations

Funding is a critical factor in the success of election audits, which often entail high costs, including direct, operational, and human resources expenses. Some things to consider when it comes to funding election audits include:

- Funding needs to account not only for direct costs, but also for the time and personnel required to conduct audits.
- Many states prohibit or limit the use of private funding for elections, including election audits.

Sample Language

*“For the standard of **Funding**, we conduct audits... (for example)*

- *...that are funded entirely through allocations from the state or local government.”*
- *...where all necessary resources, including staffing, equipment, and secure facilities, were fully funded by state and local government allocations.”*

Impartiality

Audits must be conducted without bias, prejudice, or undue influence and instead focus solely on factual evidence to reach fair and objective conclusions.

Discussion

Bias is a natural human tendency. While it's not always harmful, unmanaged bias can undermine trust if left unchecked. Codes of conduct and ethical guidelines can help set expectations and provide a means for removing personnel should it become evident that they are acting in a biased manner.

An example of applying impartiality in election audits involves implementing safeguards to prevent election officials' personal interests in portraying an election as "successful" from influencing audit procedures or the reporting of results. It is also essential for partisan representatives and external participants to maintain vigilance against bias toward any particular candidate, party, or outcome during the audit process.

Similarly, external pressures aimed at influencing audit outcomes must be resisted. The presentation of audit results should be clear, comprehensive, and contextualized, with an accurate evaluation of the audit's findings.

Considerations

Perceived bias can be just as damaging to the credibility of an audit as actual bias.

Example

Two Examples of Bias	
Perceived Bias	When circumstances create the appearance of favoritism or lack of rigor, even if the process was fair.
Actual Bias	When personal preferences, political affiliation, or external pressure influence actions or decisions.

If circumstances exist that could cause a reasonable person to doubt the fairness or impartiality of an audit:

- Explain constraints transparently; and
- Document actions taken to preserve trust.

Sample Language

*"For the standard of **impartiality**, we conduct audits... (for example)*

- *...conducted by bi-partisan or nonpartisan boards to ensure balanced representation and fairness."*
- *...that strictly follow established standard operating procedures, minimizing the risk of bias or undue influence."*
- *...where all participants take an oath to discharge their duties faithfully."*
- *...that require disclosure of any perceived or potential biases by participants."*

Independence

Auditors, and those who design and control audits, should maintain a degree of independence from the work being audited, and neither the audit process nor results should depend solely on the chief election official.

Discussion

Independence in election audits means auditors should avoid situations where their impartiality could reasonably be questioned. While it is ideal for auditors to be entirely separate from the work being audited, practical constraints such as access to sensitive election materials often require election officials to be involved. The goal is to ensure that audit teams maintain sufficient distance from the specific processes or outcomes they are reviewing, so that the public and stakeholders can trust the results.

It is often not possible or practical for election officials to completely remove themselves from an audit process. To apply the standard of independence in election audits, a variety of strategies can be implemented to mitigate conflicts of interest and enhance impartiality.

In many cases, supervisors audit the work of their subordinates, which creates a degree of independence between the auditor and those who performed the original tasks. Similarly, state election offices often audit the work of local jurisdictions, maintaining a clear distinction between the audited entity and the auditor. Local jurisdictions might promote independence by involving officials from different departments to oversee election audits.

Additionally, statutory oversight bodies or external auditors, who are credentialed to assess government entities, should be engaged to design and conduct audits. These types of measures can help ensure that audit teams are appropriately distanced from the specific election processes or outcomes under review, thereby upholding the standard of independence and fostering public trust in audit results.

It is helpful for election officials to understand what can threaten the independence of an audit, evaluate which (if any) are relevant to their audit(s), and document any mitigations they have undertaken to safeguard the audit process. The [Quality Standards for Inspection and Evaluation](#), identifies six such threats:

- *Self-interest threat*: The threat that a financial or other interest will inappropriately influence an inspector's judgment or behavior.
- *Bias threat*: The threat that an inspector will not be objective when taking a position as a result of political, ideological, social, or other convictions.
- *Familiarity threat*: The threat that aspects of a relationship with management or personnel of an inspected entity, such as a close or long relationship, or that of an immediate or close family member, will lead an inspector to take a position that is not objective.
- *Undue influence threat*: The threat that influences or pressures from sources external to the inspection organization will affect an inspector's ability to make objective judgments.
- *Structural threat*: The threat that an inspection organization's placement within a government entity, in combination with the structure of the government entity being inspected, will affect the inspection organization's ability to perform work and report results objectively.
- *Management participation threat*: The threat that results from an individual in the inspection organization taking on the role of management in the inspected entity or otherwise performing management functions on behalf of the inspected entity, which could compromise the inspection organization's ability to perform work and report results objectively.

Considerations

When striving for independence in election audits, officials must balance ideal practices with real-world constraints. Achieving complete separation between auditors and the election work being audited is not always possible. It is important to keep in mind:

- Resource limitations may require staff to audit processes they are involved in, especially in small offices.
- Legal requirements sometimes restrict who can access sensitive election materials, limiting auditor options.
- When full independence isn't feasible, officials should disclose the conflict, document mitigation steps, and communicate them clearly to the public to maintain trust.

Sample Language

*"For the standard of **independence**, we conduct audits... (for example)*

- ...that avoid any circumstances which could cause a reasonable third party to question the auditor's independence."*
- ...that involve oversight bodies to ensure objective evaluation."*
- ...that include an external auditor on the team to strengthen independence."*

DRAFT

Competence

The audit team should collectively possess the necessary knowledge, skills, and experience to conduct an audit effectively and in compliance with professional standards, legal requirements, and the specific context of the election.

Discussion

When designing or conducting an election audit, it is generally recommended to rely on a competent team of professionals working together, rather than relying on a single auditor. A team approach can help ensure that an audit meets the standards of competence by:

- Leveraging diverse experts who bring varying knowledge, skills, and qualifications to address distinct audit needs effectively;
- Providing redundancy to maintain continuity and quality in case of emergencies or unexpected absences; and
- Providing multiple perspectives;
- Distributing workloads to maintain accuracy and thoroughness without overburdening any individual.

Having a team also makes it possible to include external participants with relevant qualifications who can bring fresh perspectives and enhance objectivity. Every audit team member should be capable of making reliable professional decisions based on established ethical principles and following a recognized code of conduct.

In practice, conducting a successful election audit typically requires involving election officials as part of the audit team. Election administration is a complex and specialized field characterized by a high degree of decentralization. Election law and practice vary significantly from state to state, and election subject matter expertise is often limited to current or former election officials. Many states also have statutory requirements regarding the custody of election equipment, materials, and records, which require election officials to maintain control over them at all times. This can limit auditors' ability to access materials needed for an audit unless the relevant election officials are involved.

Example

Audit Type	Competency Requirements
Procedural	Knowledge of laws, regulations, and standard operating procedures
Voter Registration	Knowledge of information technology, election security, and database management

The specific combination of competencies required for an audit team will depend on the type of audit being conducted. For example, a procedural audit may require experience with the statutory and regulatory rules governing elections in a particular jurisdiction or familiarity with the standard operating procedures and training materials used in an election office. Auditing a voter registration database may require additional technical skills, including team members with competencies in information technology, election security, and/or database management. Professional auditors from other sectors may also make valuable contributions in designing audit processes, as many of the broad principles of auditing are universally applicable.

Regarding areas that require specialized skills, such as using statistical methods to determine sample sizes and what races are to be audited, outside experts (such as qualified statisticians) should be consulted. These important decisions should be made by the Independent Audit Committee.

Considerations

Building a successful audit team requires more than just assembling people; it involves striking a balance between access, independence, and expertise while managing operational realities. Some things to consider when building competent election audit teams include:

- Involving election officials is often necessary for expertise and custody requirements, but independence should be preserved.
- An audit team with varied backgrounds and perspectives helps reduce bias and strengthen objectivity.
- Audit team members should have the right skill sets for specific audit types.

Sample Language

*“For the standard of **competence**, we conduct audits... (for example)*

- ...that include an experienced election official to ensure compliance with technical and legal requirements.”*
- ...designed with input from an audit professional to strengthen methodology and processes.”*
- ...conducted by individuals with demonstrated knowledge of election practices specific to the state or jurisdiction.”*

Standardization

Audits should be a standardized part of the election process that can be planned for in the regular course of election preparation.

Discussion

Planning and preparation are essential for successful election audits, just as they are for any other component of the election process. Using standard procedures can help ensure officials know exactly what needs to be done, providing them with sufficient details about the work involved so that they can plan accordingly. By making audits a regular and expected part of the election process, administrators can better allocate resources, such as additional space or personnel, and comply with legal requirements. Consistent auditing demonstrates to the public a commitment to accountability and continuous improvement in election administration.

One approach to standardizing election audits is to establish comprehensive checklists and detailed Standard Operating Procedures (SOPs) for aspects of an audit that remain unchanged from year to year. These resources clearly outline each phase of an audit. For example, for a tabulation audit, this could include SOPs for securing ballots and verifying the chain of custody, documenting discrepancies, and compiling and publishing final reports. By outlining specific steps, officials can ensure every audit follows a consistent process. Additionally, SOPs can help provide straightforward guidelines for handling unexpected issues or exceptions that may arise during an audit. The use of these standardized tools streamlines staff training, minimizes the risk of error, and fosters predictable procedures that build public trust.

Standardizing audits does not necessarily require that every audit detail be announced in advance. For example, a state election office might perform process or procedural audits on local election offices without revealing which ones will be reviewed in advance. This approach enables each local election office to prepare for an audit if needed, regardless of whether they are selected for the audit.

Considerations

While standardization is crucial for election audits, procedures must also remain flexible enough to accommodate unforeseen circumstances. Here are key points to keep in mind:

- If audits are new or significantly changed, officials may consider running a pilot of the audit to help identify resource needs and potential challenges before formal adoption.
- State laws or regulations restrict some election information from being shared publicly. Officials should only disclose information that is legally allowed.
- Standardization should not prevent local adaptation; procedures may need to be tailored to fit the size, resources, or statutory requirements of each jurisdiction.
- When exceptions to standard procedures are necessary, deviations should be documented and justified to maintain transparency and accountability.

Sample Language

*“For the standard of **standardization**, we conduct audits... (for example)*

- *...where officials are familiar with procedures in advance and so they can accurately estimate the resources required for completion.”*
- *...supported by Standard Operating Procedures that are published before the election, ensuring clarity and consistency.”*
- *...where all staff receive training using detailed checklists to guarantee uniform application of procedures.”*

Appropriateness

The scope, evidence, and methods of the audit should be clearly defined and correspond to the goals of the audit.

Discussion

An appropriately scoped election audit will not cover every aspect of an election. Instead, officials often conduct multiple audits to examine different processes. Each audit should have:

- Specific rationale for why a particular subject is being examined;
- An explanation of how such examination serves the public good; and
- Enough resources to support the audit.

An audit may be conducted on a specific process because it is new or has been recently updated, aiming to verify that the changes were applied correctly. Alternatively, an audit might routinely review the most crucial aspects of a process to ensure election integrity and reassure the public. Regardless of the reason for choosing a particular audit focus, officials should clearly communicate both the purpose of an audit and its benefits to the public.

Officials should provide a clear explanation of why specific evidence is chosen for an audit, ensuring it is both relevant and sufficient to meet the audit's goals. The kind of evidence, sample size, and sampling method should align with an audit's purpose. For audits intended to yield general conclusions about items such as ballots or voting equipment, random sampling is typically necessary for reliable results. If there are concerns about a specific part of the process, focusing the sample on that particular area may be more appropriate.

An audit's methodology must also be carefully developed to address the requirements of the audit. The methodology should describe in detail how evidence will be collected and analyzed, identify any risks or limitations (e.g., privacy, confidentiality, security, etc.), and explain how these will be mitigated. Existing statutory guidelines, regulations, and standard operating procedures should guide what is "correct" in the context of the election. For example, a tabulation audit should rely on the same standards for interpreting a voter's marks on a ballot, commonly called "voter intent," that election officials use. Engaging qualified auditors or statisticians in the development of audit processes can significantly enhance the quality of an audit by ensuring that relevant evidence is examined, samples are selected according to best practices, and analyses are conducted to fulfill the audit's goals.

Considerations

When planning an election audit, it is important to keep in mind:

- No one audit can check everything.
- Officials should be able to explain why an audit is being conducted and how it serves the public.

Sample Language

*“For the standard of **appropriateness**, we conduct audits... (for example)*

- *...that use random sampling methods as required by statute to ensure the audit scope and methodology align with legal standards.”*
- *...that verify and document the chain of custody for all materials examined, providing evidence that integrity was maintained throughout the process.”*
- *...that include all contests required by law, ensuring compliance with statutory mandates.”*

Efficacy

Audits should be conducted with a clear purpose in mind, be completed in time for the results to be useful, and include a plan for analyzing and utilizing the results and/or data gathered during the audit.

Discussion

For an audit to be effective, it requires:

- Clear goals; and
- Results that accomplish those goals.

Before conducting an audit, officials should clearly define what the audit seeks to discover, how it will achieve this goal, and what the various outcomes of the audit may



be. Each audit should clearly define what it will cover and what it will not. Following an audit, it's important to regularly review and update policies and procedures to ensure alignment with advancements in election technology and practices.

A practical example of applying the standard of efficacy to election audits is determining the optimal timing to conduct an audit that is effective for its intended purpose. For instance, if the audit is intended to validate or correct the outcome of an election, an official may determine that it should be completed before the election results are certified. However, an evaluation of poll worker materials aimed at guiding the development of future poll worker training programs may not need to be finalized before certification, as its primary purpose is to support improvements for subsequent election cycles.

Example

Audit Type	Defined Goals	Determining Effective Timing
Post-Election Tabulation Audit	Confirm correct outcomes	Before certifying election outcomes
Poll Worker Materials Audit	Improve training programs	Before the next training cycle

Considerations

In some instances, officials may not possess the necessary authority to make decisions that could enhance the effectiveness of audits. For example, the selection of contests for tabulation audits is often predetermined before the elections, as required by state law. If an uncontested race or one with a candidate winning by a substantial margin is chosen for the audit, it may not strengthen confidence in the election outcomes. Conversely, conducting an audit of a closely contested election could be more impactful in reinforcing trust in the outcome, though selecting that race for auditing after an election might not always be permitted under state law.

Officials are likely to conduct multiple and different types of audits throughout the election cycle to provide insight into different things. It's important to keep in mind:

- No one audit can check every part of the election.
- State laws or regulations often outline the scope of election audits, which means officials might not have the authority to make certain decisions impacting effectiveness.

Sample Language

*"For the standard of **efficacy**, we conduct audits... (for example)*

- ...that confirm the accuracy of the election outcomes within the legally required timeframe for certifying results."*
- ...of poll worker performance before the next election cycle, using findings to improve training and optimize assignments."*
- ...with defined escalation processes for addressing discrepancies, including investigation, resolution, and reporting to appropriate authorities if needed."*

Flexibility

Audit processes must include ways to identify and respond to unexpected challenges or constraints.

Discussion

Auditing in practice often requires flexibility due to variations in election systems and administrative structures across the country. Audit procedures need to be able to adapt to:

- Differences in state and local election systems; and
- A wide variety of policies and practices.

Audit staffing illustrates how flexibility may be exercised. In certain states, election administration is organized around bipartisan teams through a process known as "party-balancing." Audits in these jurisdictions typically adhere to this principle by pairing members from different parties to review each other's work during an audit. In contrast, other states employ strictly nonpartisan election workers, where disclosing or requesting party affiliation is not permitted.

Example

Differences in Audit Staffing	
	
Bipartisan Model	

	Nonpartisan Model
Bipartisan teams check each other's work.	Nonpartisan staff maintain neutrality.

When unforeseen circumstances arise, such as when scheduled party-affiliated workers are unable to participate in an audit, officials should evaluate whether the intended goal of the audit can be achieved through other means, such as inviting bipartisan observers to ensure cross-party representation. However, any modifications to standard procedures should be carefully assessed and clearly justified before implementation. This example demonstrates that flexibility in audit processes enables officials to consider various methods for achieving audit goals.

Considerations

Unforeseen circumstances may affect the timelines and processes associated with election audits, requiring temporary modifications to established procedures. Officials must often respond promptly to unexpected challenges. It's important to keep in mind:

- Standard operating procedures cannot anticipate every scenario; adjusting procedures often involves judgment decisions.
- As election audit policies and technologies change, process adjustments may be necessary.
- Adjustments to procedures should aim to uphold the original intent of an audit, even when exact compliance is not possible.
- Clear documentation of any deviations helps maintain trust and accountability.

Sample Language

*"For the standard of **flexibility**, we conduct audits... (for example)*

- *...with contingency plans to address unexpected challenges such as staffing shortages, to maintain audit integrity even when personnel shortages occur."*
- *...with procedures to adapt audit operations when space or security constraints require changes to the original plan."*

Privacy/Confidentiality

Confidential data and voter privacy should be protected in accordance with applicable laws and regulations. Where these constraints limit public disclosure, they should be explained.

Discussion

Many scenarios in election administration require privacy protection to prevent the misuse or exposure of personal data. Privacy concerns during election audits depend on various factors, such as:

- The portion of the election process being audited;
- The type of evidence being examined;
- The degree of public disclosure; and
- The laws and regulations in a given state or jurisdiction.

In practice, applying the audit standard of privacy/confidentiality means that officials should ensure that all sensitive information is safeguarded in compliance with applicable laws and regulations during the election audit.

The most common form of voter privacy protection is the secret ballot, which guarantees that individual ballots remain untraceable to specific voters. Audits that examine physical paper ballots, images of scanned ballots, and/or cast vote records should maintain voter privacy, especially if audit materials are publicly disclosed. Hand-marked ballots may occasionally contain stray marks or handwriting, and certain ballots can include distinctive votes or patterns that could unintentionally link a ballot to an individual voter (such as a write-in vote for a unique name). While it is strictly prohibited to alter any portion of a physical ballot, some voting technologies can redact nonessential marks from ballot images to address privacy concerns before these images are released to the public.

Example

Core Principle: The Secret Ballot
A secret ballot refers to a set of rules and procedures to establish the fundamental right of voters in the United States to cast a secret ballot. These procedures ensure that no ballot can be associated with a voter, thereby allowing voters to mark their ballots freely and without fear of repercussion or reprisal.

Privacy challenges can also arise when auditing election results from precincts with a small number of ballots. For example, if only one ballot is cast in a precinct during a low-turnout election, auditors may be able to identify a specific voter if mitigation measures are not used to protect the voter's privacy. Even with a handful of ballots, if most voters choose the same candidate, the risk remains. To alleviate this type of concern, the public reporting of election results and tabulation audit results may combine precincts with small numbers of votes cast into a single, larger precinct to protect voter privacy.

Similar concerns apply to unique ballot types, such as Federal Write-In Absentee Ballots (FWABs), Uniformed and Overseas Citizens Absentee Voting Act (UOCAVA) ballots, or accessible ballots, which may stand out from standard ballots and make it easier to identify individual voters.

Considerations

While the examples discussed in this section focus on the importance of protecting voters' right to a secret ballot during an audit, voter privacy extends beyond the anonymity of individual ballots. As audits are planned, officials should carefully evaluate potential risks to voter privacy and take measures to mitigate them wherever feasible. Key considerations include:

- Officials should identify privacy risks early and address them when possible.
- Audits frequently necessitate balancing privacy protections and transparency.
- Some privacy solutions may require resources that are not readily accessible, making planning ahead essential.

Sample Language

*"For the standard of **privacy/confidentiality**, we conduct audits... (for example)*

- *...that safeguard personally identifiable information such as Social Security numbers, ensuring compliance with privacy laws."*
- *...that protect voter signatures during ballot signature verification, limiting access and disclosure to authorized personnel only."*
- *...that ensure individual ballots are never linked to a voter's identity, preserving the secrecy of the vote."*

Security

Audits should follow established security best practices and be conducted with trusted technology and personnel. Nothing done in the course of the audit should prevent election officials from using audited equipment, ballots, or other records for their intended election purpose.

Discussion

Audit security involves safeguarding election records and equipment during audit processes. Audit security builds on the physical and cyber protections already in place for elections. The goal is to ensure that nothing is permanently changed, destroyed, or lost during the audit.

Audit procedures should be designed to ensure the records and equipment remain secure throughout the process. Officials often use different methods to protect election audits, as illustrated in the following examples.

Examples

- **Ballot Handling:** When hand counts involve individual ballots, it is common to identify audited ballots with removable labels and use placeholders to indicate where a ballot was removed from its original storage location. This ensures that the ballot can be returned to its original position. Many offices also mandate that only red pens be used when handling voted ballots, since tabulators can be configured to ignore red marks, preventing accidental changes to votes.
- **Voting Equipment:** Audit equipment should be handled to maintain warranties, certifications, and chain-of-custody records, noting that requirements may vary by equipment type, manufacturer, or jurisdiction. Post-election procedures may include a comprehensive review of voting system components to ensure that no unauthorized modifications have been made to software, configurations, or firmware during the election period. This process typically involves examining system logs, evaluating seal records, and verifying that all equipment remains in its certified state.
- **Chain of Custody:** Documentation should continue throughout the audit, logging the movement of records or equipment and noting when each is accessed, unsealed, or resealed.
- **Venue Security:** When audits are conducted in facilities where election equipment or ballots are stored, it is important to keep those items secure. This can be accomplished through security measures such as monitoring who enters and exits the facility, using methods to easily identify individuals in different roles

(e.g., election observers, auditors, the public), and establishing clear boundaries to separate restricted and public areas.

- **Access Control:** Officials can control access by using locks, seals, and security concepts such as the Principle of Least Privilege, which only gives each person involved in the audit access to the records or equipment necessary to fulfill their assigned role.
- **Hash Verification:** When supported by state certification processes and vendor configurations, officials may check the voting system software by comparing its cryptographic hash value to the official certified version. This helps confirm the software was not changed without permission. Not all voting system technologies support hash verification. Where this is not possible, equivalent integrity checks (e.g., seal audits, configuration logs, authorized access logs) may still confirm system integrity.

These examples illustrate some methods officials use to secure election audits, but they are not an exhaustive list of all available strategies.

Considerations

When applying audit security standards, key considerations include:

- Officials must ensure all procedures comply with applicable laws and election regulations.
- Security measures may need to be adjusted based on the staffing, space, and technology resources.
- Potential vulnerabilities and the level of safeguards can vary depending on local circumstances.

Sample Language

*“For the standard of **security**, we conduct audits... (for example)*

- *...that document the chain of custody of all election materials and equipment.”*
- *...where all ballots and audit materials are stored in secure, access-controlled environments to prevent unauthorized handling.”*
- *...that require two authorized individuals to be present whenever election materials are accessed or moved.”*

Public Communication

Election officials should communicate with the public about the goal(s), process, and outcome of the audit to promote public confidence.

Discussion

When audits are intended to enhance public confidence, public communication can play a crucial role in the audit's overall success. For stakeholders to place trust in an audit, it is generally helpful if they are aware that the audit is taking place and have at least a basic understanding of its purpose and process. However, the complexity and relative unfamiliarity of election administration and auditing can present challenges to effective communication. While strong communication is a valuable step, it may not always be feasible to provide comprehensive information to all audiences, and approaches will necessarily vary based on local circumstances and resource availability. As a general practice, it is advisable to provide public notice of an audit before it takes place, and to share a summary, including the audit's goals, a high-level overview of the process, and the outcome, once the audit is complete. Still, the specific timing, content, and format of public communication will vary for each jurisdiction.

In addition to the publishing of election results, the Independent Audit Committee should produce a report discussing additional information on the performance of the audit, such as how well the county performed various aspects of the election including organization, chain of custody, ballot reconciliation, and other functions.

Public communication of election audits should aim to make information available, understandable, and credible. Officials can employ a variety of strategies to communicate with the public. The following examples illustrate some common ways officials may communicate with the public about election audits:

- **Public Observation:** Providing an open invitation for public observation of an audit remains one of the most common ways to provide direct access to the audit process, allowing the public to see what is happening rather than just reading or hearing about it. However, legal, resource, or security constraints may limit this option, and attendance is often low even when observation is offered.
- **Accessible Information:** Many election officials have created web pages, fact sheets, or brochures that provide a concise overview and key information about election audits, written in plain language and designed for an audience with no prior knowledge about elections. General audiences may find high-level

summaries of the audit process most reassuring, because they demonstrate election officials' ongoing commitment to quality assurance.

- **Media Engagement:** Inviting local media outlets to attend and report on election audits, including, for example, logic and accuracy testing of voting equipment before an election, can create opportunities to reach a wider audience.
- **Performance Report:** After the completion of the audit the Election Audit Commission should issue a public report describing the election processes – what went well and what can be improved upon.

The examples provided represent just a few of the ways that officials communicate with the public about election audits. Each office develops communication strategies that fit its available resources, legal obligations, and the needs of its community.

Considerations

When planning public communication strategies for audits, considerations include:

- Communication strategies must comply with applicable laws and statutes.
- Officials are encouraged to use clear, accessible language and formats suitable for individuals with no prior knowledge of election administration.
- Communication methods may be subject to available staff, technology, and budget.

Sample Language

*“For the standard of **public communication**, we conduct audits... (for example)*

- *...supported by easy-to-understand fact sheets or FAQs that outline the purpose and steps of the audit.”*
- *...accompanied by visual resources such as videos or infographics to help the public understand the process.”*
- *...where press releases and social media updates keep the public informed about timelines and findings.”*

Transparency

The goals, methods/procedures, and results of the audit should be clearly documented and publicly accessible, consistent with applicable law and regulation. Public observation of the audit process is desirable but must not interfere. Where constraints are present, they should be explained.

Discussion

Transparency is vital in election audits because it builds public trust and confidence in the electoral process. When an audit process is open and accessible, voters, candidates, and stakeholders can see that officials are committed to fairness, accuracy, and accountability. Transparency allows the public to understand how audits are conducted, what safeguards are in place, and how results are verified. Ultimately, transparent audits demonstrate that officials are dedicated to upholding the integrity of elections and are willing to be held accountable for their work.

The auditors must have access to all election artifacts, including, but not limited to, original voter-marked paper ballots, chain of custody records, reconciliation records, and cast vote records. The auditors must follow state and county laws and regulations regarding the protection of voter confidentiality and should sign agreements to that effect.

Officials are encouraged to prioritize transparency throughout the audit process. A common way to achieve this is by letting the public observe, for example, the hand-counting part of a tabulation audit. If space, staff, or security issues limit the number of people who can watch an audit in person, officials can use alternative methods to maintain transparency. For example, officials might set up live video streams so anyone can watch an audit as it happens or review it afterward. Another option is to allow small groups of observers to take turns watching in person in shifts. Officials commonly employ codes of conduct, briefings, and written guides to establish clear expectations for observers and supply them with the necessary information to comprehend audit procedures, terminology, and objectives. Using these types of approaches can help officials ensure that the public can truly see and understand what is happening during an audit.

Beyond public observation, transparency in election audits can be reinforced through consistently open communication, clear documentation, and accessibility of information. By publishing comprehensive audit reports, making procedures and criteria publicly available, and proactively addressing questions and concerns from stakeholders, officials can demonstrate a commitment to transparency and openness. Ultimately, making transparency a core principle of the audit process requires that it be accessible, easy to understand, and as open to public scrutiny as permitted by law.

Considerations

When applying the standard of transparency, officials must also protect sensitive information and adhere to legal constraints:

- Depending on the jurisdiction, some data, such as personally identifiable voter information, might be legally required to remain confidential.
- Each office must strike the right balance between openness and privacy, adjusting procedures as needed for its unique situation.

Sample Language

*“For the standard of **transparency**, we conduct audits... (for example)*

- ...communicated in plain language without jargon, making information accessible and understandable to the public.”*
- ...with documented procedures, materials, reports, and results that are available for public review.”*
- ...that allow physical observation or live-streaming of the process, and we post results publicly.”*